



complete while female. It was a massive and vital social movement, run by women for the benefit of women. It didn't happen that long ago. And yet, whenever I give talks on the subject, the majority of people in the audience do not know this history. They are gratifyingly indignant about the gap in their educations.

Writing women's history is not my full-time job. By day I work at the Smithsonian Institution, one of the great archives and interpreters of American history. The Smithsonian takes that role very seriously. So, we have launched the Smithsonian American Women's History Initiative, with ambitious plans to design exhibitions, develop programs, hire curators, and expand the national collection to better portray how women have shaped this country. After all, history that includes the role of women is more accurate history. This book is an important step in the right direction.

My grandmother Lindy Boggs—born before women could vote—eventually represented the 2nd District of Louisiana in Congress, and then, in her 80s, became the

US ambassador to the Vatican. She was, in her unfailingly gracious and deceptively polite way, a pioneering champion of women's rights. Her political philosophy was this: you can accomplish anything you want, as long as you don't need to get the credit for it. It is, when you think about it, a pretty radical approach to making history, and one that is perhaps peculiarly female. Maybe women are missing from our history books not just because the books have too long been written by men, for men, about men. Maybe scores of women just quietly changed the world without stopping to make sure history gave them credit. Here's hoping this book, and many more, will give them the credit they would not claim for themselves.

*Felicia B. Polak*